



Olympus E-5

Olympus E-5 will start shipping from October end and is expected to sell at \$1,700

Fujifilm's new line up

Fujifilm has announced three new cameras: REAL 3D W3, FinePix F300EXR and FinePix Z800EXR

which is substantial by any means.

Karbonn and Lava are two other companies in the dual-SIM market that are slowly but surely catching up. The basic strategy is the same – release entry-level, dual-SIM cellphones. Recently Lava has tied up with the National Geographic Channel (NGC) to pre-load NGC content on all Lava handsets. Videocon has also released an Android offering in the form of Zeus.

All-in-all, the cellphone market is seeing a lot of challengers. Since the price barrier has been conquered, the only way for these companies to survive is to up their innovation ante, and improve on the after-sales service. Nokia is the undisputed ruler right now as far as the numbers go, but for once we really don't know what the future holds.

DIGITAL CAMERAS

Canon, Sony and Nikon have dominated the digital camera market, as far as India is concerned. According to market share figures in India, Canon is the leader in the dSLR segment, while Sony rules the point-and-shoot arena.

If we consider the number of models launched across all categories, from January 2008 to date – Canon 58, Nikon 51, Sony 60, Olympus 55, Panasonic 59 – it's obvious that everyone's releasing the same amount of new models. The difference lies in the fact that Olympus and Panasonic launched many more point-and-shoots, while Canon, Nikon and Sony launched more mid- and high-end models. These are the ones that make the headlines, and the results of this are highlighted when you look at the Google Insights data – Olympus and Panasonic trail the top three by a huge margin.

However, both these manufacturers are responsible for one innovative technology in particular that has caught our attention – the Micro Four Thirds standard. It was introduced by Olympus and Panasonic in 2008. This technology does away with the mirror inside a dSLR camera, thus allowing the same sensor size

as most entry-level dSLRs, but with sleeker camera bodies.

Olympus has three cameras in this series – the PEN E-P1, E-P2 and E-PL1 – whereas Panasonic has five cameras here, including the Lumix DMC-G1, G2, G10 and GH1 among others. The success of this format can be gauged from the fact that Sony and Samsung have also come out with Micro Four Thirds – Sony's NEX3 and NEX5 and Samsung's NX10. Canon and Nikon, so far have not come out with any cameras in this segment. Clearly, Olympus and Panasonic have a first mover advantage in this segment.

While Panasonic has a good pan India presence with over 100 branded shops, Olympus severely lacks the same. One of the main reasons Canon, Sony and Nikon are top-of-the-line, as far as camera sales is concerned, is due to their robust network in the country. Apart from service centres and dealerships spread across the length and breadth of the country, Canon, Sony and Nikon also have exclusive showrooms. To pose a threat to this domination, Panasonic and Olympus will just have to increase their presence in the country.

Advertising spends of each of the big three – Canon, Nikon and Sony – are much higher than the budgets that Olympus and Panasonic have, combined!

It's obvious that both Olympus and Panasonic need to create more awareness about their innovations. Canon has a thriving community of photographers with a program called Canon Edge, thus reinforcing brand value. Nikon has also innovated on the advertising front by having a product placement in a Bollywood movie. It is about time



Olympus E-P2 is one of the Micro Four Thirds - system camera

Olympus and Panasonic went beyond traditional methods of advertising.

As of now, Olympus and Panasonic are no threats to the top three. But they have a winner on their hands with the Micro Four Thirds camera. In the future other players may get into this, but both Olympus and Panasonic need to leverage this innovation as the market for dSLR's is on the rise according to industry reports. From just 20,000 units sold, industry estimates

put the annual sales of dSLR units to around 40,000 – a major chunk of which is expected to come from entry-level dSLRs.

Because Micro Four Thirds system cameras drop the mirror section, there is no scope to have a viewfinder in these cameras. So all you have to rely on is the electronic viewfinder

HDTVs

The HDTV market is currently ruled by Sony which has around 25 per cent market share. The LCD TV market is expected to grow from 16 lakh units last year to 27 lakh units in FY 2010-11. This is one category where the top three rule the roost comprehensively.

Videocon seems to be the only brand at present which can provide a hint of a challenge to the top three. With many players entering the DTH market, we are seeing a lot of LCD TV sales being bundled with one or the other DTH service provider. Videocon has already introduced satellite LCD TVs in the market, an industry first, that come along with complimentary subscription of the Videocon d2h DTH service. Satellite LCD TVs bypass the need to purchase a set top box (STB). Also Videocon is setting up a TV manufacturing unit at Manamadurai in Tamil Nadu

Must Read

<http://bit.ly/bNSISX>
Everything you wanted to know about Micro Four Thirds